Grade 9 English HL – Exam Study Notes

Oct 12, 2026 · @troy

Paper 2 is 2 hours for 70 marks. These notes cover Section D, Language in context (20 marks), in depth. Exam tips for Sections A–C come at the end.

Section D: Language in context

1. Parts of speech, synonyms and antonyms

A word's part of speech depends on its **job in the sentence**, not the word itself. *Light* is a noun in *Switch on the light*, a verb in *Light the candle*, and an adjective in *a light bag*.

Nouns

Type	Meaning	Examples
Common	General name, no capital	*city, teacher, phone*
Proper	Specific name, always a capital	*Paarl, Monday, Mrs Botha*
Concrete	Can be touched or seen	*table, rain*
Abstract	Ideas, feelings, qualities	*love, freedom, honesty*
Collective	A group as one unit	*a **pride** of lions, a **swarm** of bees, a **flock** of sheep, a **team** of players*
Compound	Two words joined	*toothbrush, mother-in-law, bus stop*

Abstract nouns are often made with suffixes: *brave → bravery*, *happy → happiness*, *free → freedom*, *decide → decision*, *enjoy → enjoyment*.

Pronouns

Type	Examples	Use
Personal (subject)	*I, you, he, she, it, we, they*	Does the action: ***She** ran.*
Personal (object)	*me, you, him, her, it, us, them*	Receives the action: *Call **me**.*

Type	Examples	Use
Possessive	*mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs*	*The book is **mine**.* (no apostrophe)
Reflexive	*myself, yourself, themselves*	Action turns back: *He hurt **himself**.*
Relative	*who, whom, whose, which, that*	Starts an adjective clause: *the girl **who** sang*
Demonstrative	*this, that, these, those*	Points out: ***This** is mine.*
Interrogative	*who, what, which, whose*	Asks: ***Who** called?*
Indefinite	*everyone, someone, nobody, each*	Takes a singular verb: *Everyone **is** here.*

Common mistakes:

- *Me and Sipho went → Sipho and **I** went* (subject). Test: remove the other person — *I went*, not *me went*.
- *between you and I → between you and **me*** (after a preposition use the object form).
- *who* is for people, *which* is for things: *the dog **which** barked*, *the man **who** called*.

Verbs

Verbs show action (*run*), link the subject to a description (*is, seem, become*), or help the main verb (*have, will, can*). Tenses are in section 8.

Adjectives

Adjectives describe nouns and pronouns. They answer *which? what kind? how many?*

Degree	Short words	Long words	Irregular
Positive	*tall*	*beautiful*	*good / bad / many*
Comparative (2 things)	*taller*	*more beautiful*	*better / worse / more*
Superlative (3+ things)	*tallest*	*most beautiful*	*best / worst / most*

Common mistakes: *more better*, *most tallest* (never double up); *the best of the two → the better of the two*.

Adverbs

Adverbs describe verbs, adjectives or other adverbs. They answer *how? when? where? how often? to what extent?*

- Manner: *quickly, carefully* · Time: *yesterday, soon* · Place: *here, outside* · Frequency: *always, never* · Degree: *very, extremely, too*
- *good* is an adjective, *well* is the adverb: *She sings **well*** (not *good*).
- Not every *-ly* word is an adverb: *friendly, lovely, lonely* are adjectives.

Prepositions, conjunctions, articles, interjections

- **Prepositions** show the relationship of a noun to another word (place, time, direction): *in, on, at, under, between, during, towards*. A preposition is always followed by a noun or pronoun: *under **the table***.
- **Conjunctions** join words or clauses (see section 2).
- **Articles:** *a* before consonant **sounds**, *an* before vowel **sounds** — *an hour*, *a university*, *an MP*. *The* = a specific one.
- **Interjections** show sudden emotion: *Oh no! Wow! Ouch!*

Synonyms and antonyms

- **Synonym:** a word with the same or nearly the same meaning — *angry / furious*, *begin / commence*, *brave / courageous*, *small / tiny*.
- **Antonym:** a word with the opposite meaning — *ancient / modern*, *generous / mean*, *expand / contract*.
- Antonyms with prefixes: *un-* (unkind), *dis-* (dishonest), *in-* (incorrect), *im-* before *p/m/b* (impossible, immature), *il-* before *l* (illegal), *ir-* before *r* (irregular), *non-* (nonsense), *mis-* (misunderstand).
- In the exam the synonym must be the **same part of speech** and fit the sentence. If the word is a verb in past tense, your synonym must be too (*sprinted → ran*, not *run*).

2. Types of sentences and conjunctions (pp. 277, 268)

A sentence's type depends on how many **clauses** it has and how they are joined. A clause is a group of words with a subject and a finite verb.

Sentence structure

Type	Made of	Example
Simple	One main clause (one finite verb)	*The learners wrote the test.*
Compound	Two or more main clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction or semicolon	*The learners wrote the test,* ***but*** *they did not finish.*
Complex	One main clause + at least one subordinate clause	***Although*** *they studied,* the learners did not finish.
Compound-complex	Two main clauses + a subordinate clause	*When the bell rang, the learners stopped writing* ***and*** *the teacher collected the papers.*

How to identify the type:

1. Find every finite verb (a verb with a subject and a tense).
2. One finite verb = simple. A simple sentence can be long: *The tired old dog slept under the tree in the garden all afternoon* is still simple.
3. Two clauses: if both make sense alone and are joined by FANBOYS = compound. If one starts with a subordinating word and cannot stand alone = complex.

Sentence purpose

Type	Purpose	Ends with	Example
Declarative (statement)	Gives information	.	*The shop opens at eight.*
Interrogative (question)	Asks	?	*When does the shop open?*
Imperative (command)	Instructs or requests	. or !	*Close the door.*
Exclamatory	Shows strong feeling	!	*What a beautiful day!*

Combining sentences — a common exam question

Two simple sentences: *It was raining. We played outside.*

- Compound: *It was raining,* ***but*** *we played outside.*
- Complex: ***Although*** *it was raining, we played outside. | We played outside* ***even though*** *it was raining.*

- With a relative pronoun: *My brother lives in Cape Town. He is a doctor.* → *My brother, **who** lives in Cape Town, is a doctor.*
- With a participle: *She opened the letter. She smiled.* → ***Opening** the letter, she smiled.*

When asked to combine, do not just add *and*: check the instruction (e.g. "use a conjunction of contrast").

Conjunctions

Coordinating — FANBOYS: *for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so*. They join equal parts. Put a comma before them when joining two main clauses.

Subordinating start a subordinate clause. Group them by meaning — exam questions often ask for a conjunction showing a particular relationship:

Meaning	Conjunctions
Time	*when, while, before, after, until, as soon as, since*
Reason / cause	*because, since, as*
Contrast / concession	*although, though, even though, whereas, while*
Condition	*if, unless, provided that, as long as*
Purpose	*so that, in order that*
Result	*so…that, such…that*
Place	*where, wherever*

Correlative (pairs): *either…or*, *neither…nor*, *both…and*, *not only…but also*, *whether…or*.

- With *either/or* and *neither/nor*, the verb agrees with the **nearer** subject: *Neither the teacher nor the learners **were** late. | Neither the learners nor the teacher **was** late.*
- *Neither* goes with *nor*, never *or*.

Conjunctive adverbs (*however, therefore, moreover, nevertheless, consequently*) are not conjunctions. They need a semicolon or full stop before them: *It rained; **however**, we still played.*

Common mistakes:

- Comma splice: *It was late, we went home.* → *It was late, **so** we went home.* or *It was late; we went home.*
- Starting with *because* and never finishing: *Because I was tired.* is a fragment, not a sentence.

- *Although…but* together: *Although it rained, but we played* → drop *but*.

3. Phrases, clauses and syntax (pp. 267, 271, 272)

The test is simple: a **clause** has a subject and a finite verb; a **phrase** does not.

Phrases

A phrase is a group of words that works as one part of speech but has no finite verb.

Phrase type	Does the job of	Example
Noun phrase	A noun	***The old wooden bridge*** *collapsed.*
Adjective phrase	An adjective (describes a noun)	*The girl* ***with the red hair*** *won.*
Adverb phrase	An adverb (how, when, where)	*He arrived* ***in a great hurry****. | We met* ***after school****.*
Prepositional phrase	Starts with a preposition; acts as adjective or adverb	***under the bed****,* ***during the match***
Verb phrase	The main verb + helpers	*She* ***has been waiting****.*
Participial phrase	Starts with an *-ing* or *-ed* word; describes a noun	***Running for the bus****, she tripped.*
Infinitive phrase	Starts with *to* + verb	*He wants* ***to become a pilot****.*

Clauses

Main (independent) clause makes sense on its own: *I went home*.

Subordinate (dependent) clause cannot stand alone. It starts with a subordinating conjunction or relative pronoun: *because I was ill*.

There are three types of subordinate clause. Ask what job the clause does.

Clause	Job	Starts with	Example
Adjective (relative) clause	Describes a noun; comes right after it	*who, whom, whose, which, that, where, when*	*The phone* ***that I bought*** *is broken.*

Clause	Job	Starts with	Example
Adverb clause	Tells how, when, where, why, under what condition	*because, when, if, although, until, so that*	*We left **when the movie ended**.*
Noun clause	Acts as a noun (subject or object)	*what, that, whether, how, why, who*	***What she said** surprised everyone. / I know **that you tried**.*

Tip: to test for a noun clause, replace it with *it* or *something*: *Something surprised everyone.* If the sentence still works, it is a noun clause.

Defining vs non-defining adjective clauses:

- Defining (no commas, needed to know which one): *The learners **who studied** passed.* (only those learners)
- Non-defining (commas, extra information): *My mother, **who is a nurse**, works nights.* (I only have one mother)
- *That* is only used in defining clauses.

Syntax: subject, verb, object

Syntax is the order of words in a sentence. English usually follows **Subject → Verb → Object** (SVO).

Part	Question to find it	Example: *The coach gave the team a talk.*
Subject	Who or what does the action?	*The coach*
Verb	What is done?	*gave*
Direct object	Who or what receives the action? (verb + what?)	*a talk*
Indirect object	To or for whom?	*the team*

- Find the verb first, then ask *who/what + verb?* to find the subject.
- In questions the order changes: *Did **you** see the game?*
- Changing word order changes emphasis or meaning: *Only I saw him* vs *I only saw him* vs *I saw only him*.

Concord (subject–verb agreement)

A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb.

- Find the true subject, ignoring phrases in between: *The box **of chocolates** is on the table.* (subject = box)
- *Each, every, everyone, nobody, either, neither* are singular: *Each of the boys **has** a bag.*
- Two subjects joined by *and* are plural: *Tom and Ayanda **are** here.*
- *As well as, along with, together with* do not make the subject plural: *The captain, as well as his players, **was** praised.*
- Collective nouns are usually singular: *The team **is** winning.*
- *There is* + singular, *there are* + plural: *There **are** many reasons.*

4. Punctuation (pp. 275–276)

Exam questions usually give a sentence with no punctuation, or ask why a mark was used. Learn each mark's job.

Full stop, question mark, exclamation mark

- **Full stop:** ends statements and commands; also after some abbreviations (*etc.*, *e.g.*).
- **Question mark:** only for direct questions. *He asked where I lived.* is reported, so no question mark.
- **Exclamation mark:** strong emotion, surprise or a forceful command. Use one, never *!!!*

Comma

Use	Example
Separate items in a list	*We bought bread, milk, eggs and butter.*
Before FANBOYS joining two main clauses	*I was tired, so I went to bed.*
After an introductory word, phrase or clause	*However, we lost. / When the bell rang, we left.*
Around extra (non-essential) information	*Mr Dlamini, our principal, spoke first.*
Before and after direct speech tags	*"Come here," she said.*
Addressing someone directly	*Thabo, please sit down. / Let's eat, Grandma.*
Before a question tag	*You're coming, aren't you?*

Use	Example
Between two or more adjectives that each describe the noun	*a long, boring speech*

Common mistake — the comma splice: two full sentences joined by only a comma. *I love rugby, my brother prefers soccer.* Fix with a full stop, semicolon, or comma + conjunction.

Apostrophe

1. Contractions — the apostrophe replaces missing letters: *do not → don't*, *it is → it's*, *they are → they're*, *would have → would've* (never *would of*).

2. Possession

Owner	Rule	Example
One owner	add *'s*	*the dog's bone*, *James's book* (or *James' book*)
Plural ending in *s*	add *'* only	*the girls' change room* (many girls)
Plural not ending in *s*	add *'s*	*the children's toys*, *the men's team*
Joint ownership	*'s* on the last name only	*Lerato and Sipho's house* (one house)
Separate ownership	*'s* on each name	*Lerato's and Sipho's phones*

Never use an apostrophe for plurals (*apple's for sale* is wrong) or for possessive pronouns: *its, yours, hers, ours, theirs*. *It's* always means *it is* or *it has*.

Colon and semicolon

- **Colon (:)** introduces a list, an explanation, or a quotation: *You need three things: a pen, a ruler and a calculator.* The part before the colon must be a complete sentence.
- **Semicolon (;)** joins two closely related main clauses without a conjunction: *The sun had set; it was getting cold.* It also separates list items that already contain commas: *Durban, KwaZulu-Natal; Paarl, Western Cape; Polokwane, Limpopo.*

Inverted commas (quotation marks)

- Direct speech: *"I'm hungry," said Pieter.*
- Quoting from a text: *The writer calls the city "a sleeping giant".*

- Titles of short works (poems, songs, articles, chapters): *"The Road Not Taken"*. Books, films and newspapers are underlined when handwritten.
- Words used in a special, ironic or sarcastic way: *His "help" made things worse.*

Dash, hyphen, brackets, ellipsis

- **Hyphen (-)** joins words into one idea: *well-known*, *twenty-one*, *mother-in-law*, *a five-year-old boy*.
- **Dash (–)** adds a dramatic pause, an afterthought or an interruption: *There was only one thing to do – run.* A pair of dashes can replace brackets.
- **Brackets ( )** add extra information the sentence would work without: *The Springboks (South Africa's rugby team) won.*
- **Ellipsis (…)** shows words left out of a quote, a trailing-off thought, or suspense: *I opened the door and…*

Why was this mark used? (exam phrasing)

When asked to explain punctuation, name the purpose and link it to the text:

- Dash: *to create a dramatic pause before the surprising information.*
- Ellipsis: *to show the speaker's voice trailing off / to build suspense / to show words have been left out.*
- Exclamation mark: *to show the writer's anger/shock.*
- Inverted commas around a single word: *to show sarcasm — the writer does not believe it is really "help".*
- Brackets: *to add extra information.*

5. Spelling, capitals, plurals, prefixes and suffixes (p. 273)

Most spelling marks come from a handful of rules. Learn the rules and the exceptions.

Capital letters

Use a capital for:

- The first word of a sentence and of direct speech: *She said, "**W**e're late."*
- The pronoun *I*.
- Names of people, places, countries, languages and nationalities: *Ayanda, Paarl, South Africa, Afrikaans, French*.
- Days, months, holidays: *Monday, November, Heritage Day*. **Not** seasons: *summer, winter*.

- Titles before a name: *Dr Mokoena, Aunt Sue*. But: *my aunt*, *the doctor*.
- Main words in titles of books, films, songs: *The Lion King*.
- Organisations, brands, religions, historical events: *Eskom, Nike, Christianity, World War II*.
- Directions only when they are part of a name: *the Northern Cape*, but *drive north*.
- School subjects only if they are languages: *English, maths, science*.

Plurals

Rule	Singular → Plural
Most words: add *-s*	*book → books*
Ends in *-s, -ss, -sh, -ch, -x, -z*: add *-es*	*bus → buses, church → churches, box → boxes*
Consonant + *y*: change *y* to *-ies*	*baby → babies, city → cities*
Vowel + *y*: just add *-s*	*day → days, key → keys, monkey → monkeys*
Ends in *-f* / *-fe*: usually *-ves*	*leaf → leaves, knife → knives, wolf → wolves*
-f exceptions: add *-s*	*roof → roofs, chief → chiefs, cliff → cliffs, belief → beliefs*
Consonant + *o*: usually *-es*	*potato → potatoes, tomato → tomatoes, hero → heroes, echo → echoes*
-o exceptions: add *-s*	*photo → photos, piano → pianos, radio → radios, zoo → zoos*
Irregular	*man → men, woman → women, child → children, foot → feet, tooth → teeth, mouse → mice, goose → geese, person → people, ox → oxen*
Same in both	*sheep, deer, fish, aircraft, series, species*
Latin / Greek	*cactus → cacti, fungus → fungi, crisis → crises, analysis → analyses, phenomenon → phenomena, criterion → criteria, datum → data*
Compound nouns: pluralise the main word	*mother-in-law → mothers-in-law, passer-by → passers-by*

Always plural: *scissors, trousers, glasses, news* (*news* takes a singular verb: *The news **is** good*).

Prefixes

A prefix goes at the **front** of a word and changes its **meaning**. The spelling of the root does not change: *dis + satisfied = dissatisfied*, *mis + spell = misspell*, *un + necessary = unnecessary*.

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un-, in-, im-, il-, ir-, dis-, non-	not	*unfair, invisible, impolite, illogical, irrelevant, disagree, non-fiction*
mis-	wrongly	*misunderstand, misbehave*
re-	again	*rewrite, rebuild*
pre-	before	*preview, prehistoric*
post-	after	*postpone, post-war*
anti-	against	*antisocial, antibiotic*
over- / under-	too much / too little	*overcook, underestimate*
sub-	under	*submarine, subway*
inter-	between	*international, interact*
trans-	across	*transport, transatlantic*
bi- / tri-	two / three	*bicycle, triangle*
auto-	self	*autobiography, automatic*

Suffixes

A suffix goes at the **end** and usually changes the **part of speech**.

Makes a…	Suffixes	Examples
Noun	*-ness, -ment, -tion/-sion, -ity, -ance/-ence, -er/-or, -ship, -hood, -dom*	*kindness, payment, decision, ability, importance, teacher, friendship, childhood, freedom*
Adjective	*-ful, -less, -ous, -able/-ible, -ive, -al, -y, -ic*	*careful, hopeless, dangerous, readable, creative, musical, sunny, heroic*
Verb	*-ise, -ify, -en*	*realise, simplify, widen*

Makes a…	Suffixes	Examples
Adverb	*-ly*	*quickly, happily*

Spelling rules when adding suffixes:

1. **Drop the silent *e*** before a vowel suffix: *hope → hoping, write → writing, believe → believable*. Keep it before a consonant suffix: *hope → hopeful, care → careless*. Exceptions: *argument, truly, ninth*; and keep *e* after *c/g* to keep the sound soft: *noticeable, courageous*.
2. **Double the final consonant** in one-syllable words ending consonant–vowel–consonant: *run → running, stop → stopped, big → bigger*. In longer words, double only if the stress is on the last syllable: *begin → beginning, prefer → preferred*, but *visit → visited, open → opening*. In SA/British spelling, final *l* doubles: *travel → travelled*.
3. **Consonant + *y* → *i*** before a suffix: *happy → happiness, carry → carried, beauty → beautiful*. Keep *y* before *-ing*: *carrying*.
4. ***-ful*** has one *l*: *careful, hopeful, spoonful*.

Other spelling rules and trouble words

- ***i* before *e* except after *c*** (when the sound is *ee*): *believe, field, receive, ceiling*. Exceptions: *weird, seize, either, neither, protein*.
- SA uses British spelling: *colour, centre, realise, programme, travelled, defence*.
- Commonly misspelt: *accommodation, necessary, separate, definitely, embarrass, occurred, rhythm, beginning, government, environment, conscience, conscious, restaurant, Wednesday, February, receive, achieve, until, tomorrow, disappear, a lot* (two words).

6. Direct and reported speech (pp. 269, 276)

Direct speech gives the speaker's exact words in inverted commas. Reported (indirect) speech retells what was said, with no inverted commas, usually one tense further back.

Punctuating direct speech

- Inverted commas go around the spoken words only.
- The first spoken word starts with a capital.
- Punctuation that belongs to the speech goes **inside** the closing inverted commas.
- A new speaker starts a new paragraph.

Pattern	Example
Speech tag first	*Mom said, "Dinner is ready."*
Speech tag last	*"Dinner is ready," Mom said.* (comma, not full stop, inside)
Question or exclamation	*"Is dinner ready?" asked Sam.* (no comma after ?; *asked* stays lower case)
Speech split in the middle	*"If you hurry," said Mom, "you'll catch the bus."* (second part continues in lower case)
Two sentences, split	*"I'm tired," said Mom. "Let's go home."* (second part is a new sentence: capital)

Changing direct to reported speech

Work through four changes every time: **tense, pronouns, time/place words, and punctuation/linking word**.

1. Tense moves one step back (when the reporting verb is in the past, e.g. *said*):

Direct	Reported
Present simple: *"I **like** pizza."*	Past simple: *He said that he **liked** pizza.*
Present continuous: *"I **am reading**."*	Past continuous: *She said that she **was reading**.*
Present perfect: *"I **have finished**."*	Past perfect: *He said that he **had finished**.*
Past simple: *"I **lost** my keys."*	Past perfect: *She said that she **had lost** her keys.*
Past perfect	Stays past perfect
will → would, *can → could*, *may → might*, *shall → should*, *must → had to*	*"I **will** help." → He said that he **would** help.*

No tense change when the reporting verb is present (*He says that he is tired*) or when reporting a fact that is still true (*She said that the earth is round*).

2. Pronouns and possessives change to fit the new speaker: *I → he/she*, *we → they*, *my → his/her*, *our → their*, *you → I/me/he/she/they* (depending on who was spoken to).

3. Time and place words:

Direct	Reported
now	*then*
today / tonight	*that day / that night*
yesterday	*the day before / the previous day*
tomorrow	*the next day / the following day*
last week	*the week before / the previous week*
next week	*the following week*
ago	*before / earlier*
here	*there*
this / these	*that / those*

4. Linking word and reporting verb:

Sentence type	Reporting verb + link	Example
Statement	*said (that), told me (that), explained that*	*"I am late," said Ben. → Ben said that he was late.*
Yes/no question	*asked if / whether*	*"Are you coming?" she asked me. → She asked me **if** I was coming.*
Wh- question	*asked* + question word; normal word order; no question mark	*"Where do you live?" he asked. → He asked where I **lived**.* (not *where did I live*)
Command	*told / ordered / commanded* + *to* + verb	*"Sit down!" said the teacher. → The teacher told us **to sit** down.*
Negative command	*told* + *not to*	*"Don't talk!" → She told us **not to** talk.*
Request	*asked / begged* + *to*	*"Please help me," she said. → She asked me to help her.*
Exclamation	*exclaimed that*, or describe the feeling	*"What a goal!" said Sipho. → Sipho exclaimed that it was a great goal.*

Words that disappear: *please, yes, no, oh, well*, names used to address someone. *"Yes, I'll go," said Lebo → Lebo agreed to go | Lebo said that she would go.*

Worked example

“I saw your brother at the mall yesterday,” Thandi told me.

1. Reporting verb: *told me + that*
2. Pronouns: *I → she*, *your → my*
3. Tense: *saw → had seen*
4. Time: *yesterday → the day before*

→ Thandi told me that she had seen my brother at the mall the day before.

Reported back to direct

Reverse every change: tense forward, pronouns back to *I/we/you*, time words back, and add inverted commas and the right end mark. *He asked whether I had finished my homework. → “Have you finished your homework?” he asked.*

7. Homophones (p. 270)

Homophones sound the same but have different spellings and meanings. The exam usually asks you to choose the correct word or correct a sentence.

The ones that are tested most

Words	Meaning and memory trick
their / there / they're	*their* = belongs to them (has *heir* in it); *there* = place (has *here* in it); *they're* = they are
your / you're	*your* = belongs to you; *you're* = you are
its / it's	*its* = belongs to it; *it's* = it is / it has. Test: if *it is* fits, use *it's*
to / too / two	*to* = towards / before a verb; *too* = also, or excessively (extra *o* = extra); *two* = 2
whose / who's	*whose* = belonging to whom; *who's* = who is / who has
were / where / wear / we're	*were* = past of *are*; *where* = place; *wear* = clothes; *we're* = we are
affect / effect	*affect* is usually the verb (Action); *effect* is usually the noun (End result). *The rain **affected** the game. The rain had an **effect** on the game.*

Words	Meaning and memory trick
then / than	*then* = time; *than* = comparison (*taller than me*)
accept / except	*accept* = receive, agree; *except* = excluding
lose / loose	*lose* = misplace or not win; *loose* = not tight (not true homophones but often confused)
quiet / quite	*quiet* = not noisy; *quite* = fairly

More pairs to know

weather (rain) / *whether* (if)	*principal* (head; main) / *principle* (a rule or belief)	*stationary* (standing still) / *stationery* (pens, paper — *e* for envelope)
break (smash) / *brake* (stop a car)	*peace* (calm) / *piece* (a part — *a piece of pie*)	*hear* (with your ear) / *here* (this place)
new / *knew* (past of know)	*know* / *no*	*right* / *write* / *rite*
sea / *see*	*son* / *sun*	*road* / *rode* / *rowed*
threw (past of throw) / *through* (in one side, out the other)	*passed* (verb: went by) / *past* (time before; beyond)	*allowed* (permitted) / *aloud* (out loud)
board (plank; committee) / *bored* (not interested)	*course* (route; subject) / *coarse* (rough)	*compliment* (praise) / *complement* (complete; go well with)
desert (dry land) / *dessert* (pudding — two *s* for *sweet stuff*)	*heard* (past of hear) / *herd* (group of animals)	*mail* / *male*
meat / *meet*	*pair* / *pear* / *pare*	*plain* / *plane*
sight (vision) / *site* (place) / *cite* (quote)	*steal* / *steel*	*tail* / *tale*
waist / *waste*	*weak* / *week*	*which* / *witch*

8. Verbs and tenses (pp. 279–280)

Every tense is built from a time (past, present, future) and an aspect (simple, continuous, perfect, perfect continuous). Learn the formula, not just examples.

Finite and non-finite verbs

- **Finite verb:** has a subject and shows tense — *She **walks**. They **were** late.* Every sentence needs one.
- **Non-finite verbs** have no tense on their own: infinitive (*to walk*), present participle (*walking*), past participle (*walked, written*). *Walking home* is not a sentence.

The 12 tenses

Example verb: *to write*.

	Simple	Continuous (*be* + *-ing*)	Perfect (*have* + past participle)	Perfect continuous (*have been* + *-ing*)
Present	*I write / she writes*	*I am writing*	*I have written*	*I have been writing*
Past	*I wrote*	*I was writing*	*I had written*	*I had been writing*
Future	*I will write*	*I will be writing*	*I will have written*	*I will have been writing*

When to use each

Tense	Use	Signal words
Present simple	Habits, facts, timetables	*always, usually, every day*
Present continuous	Happening now; temporary	*now, at the moment, currently*
Present perfect	Past action linked to now; unfinished time	*already, yet, just, ever, never, since, for*
Past simple	Finished action at a stated past time	*yesterday, last week, in 2020, ago*
Past continuous	In progress in the past, often interrupted	*while, when — I **was eating** when he called.*
Past perfect	The earlier of two past actions	*before, after, by the time — The bus **had left** before we arrived.*

Tense	Use	Signal words
Future simple	Predictions, promises, decisions	*tomorrow, next year, soon*
Future perfect	Will be finished before a future time	*by then, by Friday — I **will have finished** by Friday.*

Common mistakes:

- Present perfect with a finished time: *I have seen him yesterday → I **saw** him yesterday.*
- Mixing tenses in a paragraph. Stay in the tense you started in unless the time changes.
- *since* + a point in time (*since Monday*), *for* + a length of time (*for three days*).

Irregular verbs

Regular verbs add *-ed* (*walk → walked → walked*). Irregular verbs must be learnt.

Base	Past simple	Past participle
be	was / were	been
begin	began	begun
bite	bit	bitten
break	broke	broken
bring	brought	brought
buy	bought	bought
catch	caught	caught
choose	chose	chosen
do	did	done
drink	drank	drunk
drive	drove	driven
eat	ate	eaten
fall	fell	fallen
fly	flew	flown
forget	forgot	forgotten

Base	Past simple	Past participle
freeze	froze	frozen
go	went	gone
lay (put down)	laid	laid
lie (recline)	lay	lain
ride	rode	ridden
ring	rang	rung
rise	rose	risen
see	saw	seen
shake	shook	shaken
sing	sang	sung
speak	spoke	spoken
steal	stole	stolen
swim	swam	swum
take	took	taken
teach	taught	taught
think	thought	thought
throw	threw	thrown
wear	wore	worn
write	wrote	written

Watch out: *I **have gone**, I **have seen**, I **have done*** (never *I have went / have saw / have did*). *I **saw** it* (never *I seen it*).

Active and passive voice

- **Active:** the subject does the action — *The learners **cleaned** the classroom.*
- **Passive:** the subject receives the action — *The classroom **was cleaned** by the learners.*

How to change active to passive:

1. Move the object to the front as the new subject.
2. Use the correct form of *to be* in the **same tense** as the active verb + the past participle.

3. Put the old subject after *by* (or leave it out if it is unimportant).
4. Change pronouns: *he → him, they → them, I → me*.

Tense	Active	Passive
Present simple	*She **writes** a letter.*	*A letter **is written** by her.*
Present continuous	*She **is writing** a letter.*	*A letter **is being written** by her.*
Present perfect	*She **has written** a letter.*	*A letter **has been written** by her.*
Past simple	*She **wrote** a letter.*	*A letter **was written** by her.*
Past continuous	*She **was writing** a letter.*	*A letter **was being written** by her.*
Past perfect	*She **had written** a letter.*	*A letter **had been written** by her.*
Future	*She **will write** a letter.*	*A letter **will be written** by her.*
Modal	*She **must write** a letter.*	*A letter **must be written** by her.*

If the object is plural, the *be* verb becomes plural: *They sell **cars**. → **Cars are** sold.*

Use passive when the doer is unknown or unimportant (*My bike was stolen*), or to sound formal and objective (news reports, science).

Tips for Sections A, B and C

Time guide for Paper 2 (120 min): about 40 min for A, 15 min for B, 25 min for C, 30 min for D, and 10 min to check.

Section A: Comprehension (25 marks)

- Read the questions before the passage so you know what to look for.
- Match your answer to the marks: 2 marks = two separate points.
- Underline the instruction word. *Quote* = exact words in inverted commas. *In your own words* = do not copy. *Explain* = what + why. *Discuss / Do you agree?* = your view + a reason from the text.
- For true/false questions, give the word and a quote that proves it.
- For figures of speech: name it (simile, metaphor, personification, hyperbole, alliteration, irony, pun), then explain its effect in the passage.
- For tone or mood, give one precise word (*sarcastic*, *nostalgic*, *hopeful*) and the evidence.
- Answer in full sentences unless asked for one word.

Section B: Point-form summary (10 marks)

- Read the instruction twice: what topic, how many points, how many words.
- Underline only the facts on that topic. Skip examples, figures of speech, repetition and quotes.
- Write each point as a short, complete sentence in your own words, numbered, one idea per point.
- Do not add your own opinion.
- Count your words and write the total at the end. Going over the limit loses marks.

Section C: Visual literacy (15 marks)

- Always link what you **see** to what it **means**: *The man's clenched fists show he is angry.*
- **Cartoons:** look at facial expressions, body language, speech vs thought bubbles, bold or capital font (shouting or emphasis), and the last frame (often the joke or twist). Humour usually comes from irony, exaggeration or a pun.
- **Adverts:** identify the target audience and the clue that shows it, then discuss the slogan (puns, alliteration, rhyme), the image, colour, and persuasive language (emotive words, superlatives, imperatives, rhetorical questions).
- Know the persuasive techniques: bandwagon, celebrity endorsement, appeal to emotion, statistics, specials or free gifts, "limited time" urgency.
- If asked whether an advert is effective, give your view and two reasons from the advert itself.

Practice

Work through the four practice papers in your textbook under timed conditions: pp. 73–76, 129–131, 200–203 and 254–259. Also redo the past paper from class and reread your class handouts.